**MEMORANDUM**

To: Home Office Telecommuter Employees
From: John McPhail, President & CEO
Date: June 13, 2023
Subject: 2023 Home Office Telecommuting Arrangements

As you may already know, Partners has asked home office employees to visit work in the office at least once a week. We will also be proceeding with the following:

- **All Staff Multi-Day Gatherings (MDGs)** occur once every 3-4 months. (i.e., 3-4 gatherings per year.) These will fall during the All-Staff Meetings (ASMs), and Partners will cover all costs.
- **All Staff Gatherings (ASGs)** occur each month on the day of the All-Staff Meeting (i.e., 8-9 gatherings per year).

During these gatherings, we will schedule mandatory group collaboration and activities from 10 AM to 4 PM on average. We may adjust this to begin earlier or extend beyond on a case-by-case basis.

Since the start of the pandemic our policy on telecommuting has been constantly under review and will most likely continue to change. We want to take a moment to explain why we believe this is important for both the organization and you as individuals.

First and foremost, we value collaboration and team building within our organization. While remote work has allowed us to continue our operations during these challenging times, we believe there is no substitute for face-to-face interaction for building solid relationships and fostering a sense of teamwork. Bringing everyone together in the same physical space can strengthen our bonds as colleagues and help us work together more effectively toward our shared goals.

In addition, we believe that working remotely all the time has its drawbacks. While it can offer greater flexibility and convenience in many ways, it can also lead to feelings of isolation, burnout, and disconnection from our work and colleagues. By coming together in person more frequently than quarterly, we hope to provide a change of scenery and an opportunity for everyone to recharge and re-engage with their work and new and established colleagues.

We did not make this decision hastily and have reflected on this carefully. We understand that some challenges may be associated with coming into the office, particularly for those who have grown accustomed to working remotely.

Your decision to request fully remote work allows you a more convenient and flexible lifestyle. However, we are not being equitable with the rest of our staff. Local staff are required to come in weekly. Nor are we providing fully remote workers with all the benefits

of more frequent connections. We strongly believe that the benefits of this time together far outweigh any potential drawbacks.

As we move forward with a more intentional approach to working in the office, along with this memo, Partners has created the ***BISTEC Guiding Principles*** and illustrative examples of how to apply this in the office. Join us in this opportunity to connect with your colleagues, re-energize your work, and contribute to the success of our organization.

Thank you for your understanding and your continued commitment to Partners' mission.

Best regards,

John McPhail
President & CEO

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**BISTEC Work Guidance**

**This guidance applies to Home Office.**

**Partners recognizes that offices outside the US must develop guidelines based on business needs and applicable laws, and HR will support those efforts if needed.**

## Purpose:

Preparing and engaging previously remote employees is essential as businesses reopen and return to in-person work. The transition can be challenging, and employees may face difficulties adjusting to their new work environment. There is a greater understanding of an organization's capacity to operate efficiently and effectively without ever needing to be in the office. Conversely, the ability to build team cohesion through physical proximity and engaging in impromptu and informal collaboration has suffered. In the future, Partners wants to harness the benefits we have experienced through flexible and remote working while also re-introducing the interpersonal interactions that remain integral to our organization's culture.

## Guiding Principles:

In addition to business needs, other intentional reasons why an employee comes to the office are determined by the following principles:

- **Brainstorming & Ideation**
  - When employees are in the same room, generating new ideas and brainstorming creative solutions to problems can be more manageable. Face-to-face interactions can help stimulate creativity and inspire new ways of thinking.
- **Serving**
  - By being together, employees can share and empower each other by teaching other tools and resources to create a space where they learn, grow, and serve our local communities.
- **Trust-building**
  - Building trust and strong collegial relationships is essential for effective teamwork and collaboration. Being physically present in the same space can help build trust and rapport between team members, leading to better communication and more productive working relationships.
- **Envisioning**
  - When employees are physically present in the same space, it can be easier to align on goals and envision a shared future for the organization. In-person meetings and workshops can help clarify objectives and create a shared sense of purpose.
- **Connecting, Collaborating, Communicating**
  - Being in an office environment can provide opportunities for employees to connect and socialize with each other, which can improve morale and foster a sense of community within the organization.
  - Emphasizing cross/unit department collaboration and connections when working in the office fosters a culture of teamwork and improves organizational performance.

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## Examples of Actionable BISTEC Guiding Principles:

- Face-to-Face Interactions: Connect with colleagues to have informal conversations
- Use Shared Space: Use shared space or common areas for informal interactions between different units and help break down barriers and encourage collaboration.
- Walking/Wandering Meetings: Abandon the desk and walk to see what inspires the team or take a mental break.
- Mind Mapping: Challenge your team to create a mind map that uses only images or sketches – no words allowed.
- Lunch and Learn: Identify external or internal speakers to come in and discuss a topic openly.
- Two Truths and a Lie: This activity involves each team member sharing three statements about themselves - two true and one false. The rest of the team tries to guess which statement is a lie. This can be a fun way to get to know each other better and build trust.
- Scavenger Hunt: A scavenger hunt in the office can be a fun and engaging way to bring people together. You can create clues and riddles that lead team members to various locations in the office, and the first team to complete the hunt wins a prize.
- Group Lunch: Schedule a team lunch or breakfast where everyone brings a dish or snack to share. This is an excellent opportunity for team members to bond over food and conversation.
- Office Olympics: Create an "Office Olympics" where team members compete in various challenges, such as paper clip toss, pencil flipping, or coffee mug relay. This can be a fun way to get people moving and working together.
- Volunteer Work: Consider scheduling a group volunteer activity where team members work together to help a local charity or organization. This can be rewarding to build trust and camaraderie while giving back to the community.
- Team Building Workshops: Hire a professional team-building company to facilitate team-building activities in the office. This can be a great way to improve communication, build trust, and foster a sense of teamwork among staff.
- Game Nights: Organize a game night where team members can play board games or card games together. This can be a fun and relaxing way to build relationships and encourage socialization.

## Expenses

Partners will cover travel and hotel expenses for all of our planned All Staff Multi-Day Gatherings (MDGs), estimated to occur 3-4 times per year. Teleworkers will be responsible for all other monthly All Staff Gatherings (ASGs), unless these costs are included in your program/unit budget and approved by the Department manager (CFO, COO, Sr VP Programs, or President & CEO). To utilize unit budgets, you must provide specific reasons beyond just attending the ASG. To be clear, if travel is covered by program/unit budgets, it will require that other activities be planned and extend your trip outside of the Wednesday scheduled in-office activities.
Expenses covered by Partners or program/unit budget will be transportation from the home of record to the hotel and back and hotel expenses for authorized days only. No other travel expenses or per diem will be provided during these visits.

## Location

Partners has established the following tiers* regarding how often a telecommuter comes into the office based on the address on file:

- Tier 1 – less than 35 miles one-way
    - Once a week
- Tier 2 – between 35-70 miles one way
    - Attends Monthly ASG and one additional in-person Wednesday.
- Tier 3 – greater than 70 miles
    - Attends Monthly ASG

*Please note that if other meetings are scheduled outside the above standard schedule, these will be additional in-office days.

Employees in Tier 1 who want to relocate to a location greater than 35 or 70 miles away (Tier 2 or Tier 3) will require prior approval using the appropriate forms in the teleworker policy.

## Guidance Effective Dates

For US-Based team members, this guidance is expected to go into effect June 1, 2023

Business needs can change over time, requiring any teleworker to relocate to our Home Office location. In this scenario, the employee will be allowed to relocate at their own expense. If the employee is unwilling or unable to relocate, their continued engagement in the role may not be possible.

Feedback will be gathered to determine the effectiveness of our flexible working arrangement approach, which will be conducted annually, and changes will be implemented as appropriate. Partners will endeavor to provide a three month notice for any significant changes in the policy or your own telework status.

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# Signature Certificate

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|---|---|---|
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| Sent: | 13 Jun 2023 18:09:54 UTC | |
| Viewed: | 14 Jun 2023 21:05:19 UTC | |
| Signed: | 14 Jun 2023 21:15:13 UTC | |
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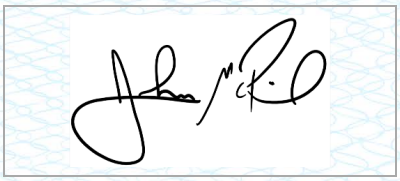

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